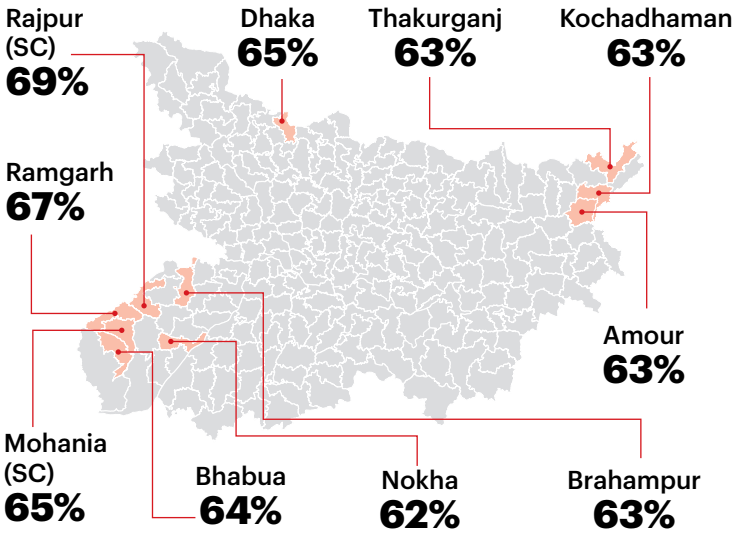
THE MISSING WOMEN

Across Bihar, they form an alarming 55% of the excluded

PERCENTAGE OF DELETED NAMES



Source: ECI (comparison based on electoral roll released on Jan. 7, 2025 and draft roll released on Aug. 1, 2025)

GIRL, DELETED

What the data conclusively reveals is a shocking gender disparity—women constitute 55 per cent of all deleted voters despite making up only 47.7 per cent of Bihar's electorate. In fact, in 43 of Bihar's 243 assembly constituencies, women account for 60 per cent or more of the deletions. The most extreme case is Rajpur, a constituency reserved for Scheduled Castes in Kaimur district, where 69 per cent of the deleted voters are women. The figure for Kaimur—a hilly, forested outback—as a whole is 64 per cent, followed closely by Buxar at 63 per cent.

This gendered pattern of exclusion reflects the deeper structural inequalities in Bihar society. Women, particularly those in rural areas, are less likely to possess the documentary proof required by the SIR. They also migrate after marriage, often lack education certificates due to lower literacy rates, and have limited interaction with government institutions that issue official documents. The irony is particularly bitter given that women voters are credited with playing a decisive role in recent Bihar elections, forming a crucial vote bank for both Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Nitish Kumar.

IN 43 OF THE 243 ASSEMBLY SEATS IN BIHAR, 60% OR MORE OF THOSE EXCLUDED FROM THE DRAFT ROLL ARE WOMEN

Their systematic exclusion threatens not just individual voting rights but the democratic legitimacy of any mandate emerging from the upcoming election.

GRAVE CONCERNS

Perhaps no aspect of the SIR has generated more controversy than the 2.23 million voters classified as deceased. Opposition parties have time and again demanded transparency about the methodology used, questioning how the ECI verified such a massive number of deaths in a state where, by the government's own admission, death registrations remain woefully low.

This opacity has fuelled speculation about arbitrary deletions, with Opposition leaders suggesting that many "dead" voters might be very much alive but temporarily absent during the SIR drive. The fear is particularly acute among families of migrant workers, estimated at over 7.4 million, who often spend months or years in other states and may have been marked deceased simply because they weren't present when officials visited.

On the ground, the SIR has also been a tragicomedy of errors at times. Booth-level officers racing against impossible deadlines have recorded fathers' names as simply 'Father', wives with the surname 'Husband'. On the flip side, in Dhanarua block of Patna district, a government clerk embroiled in a marital discord case had submitted a falsified death certificate to have his wife declared deceased and struck off the rolls. Only the diligence of an alert BLO exposed this 'electoral murder'.

The Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR) has now moved the Supreme Court, seeking directions to the ECI to publish names and specific reasons such as death, relocation or duplication for those excluded from the draft roll. While the July 20 lists shared with booth-level agents of political parties included names, EPIC ID numbers and reasons for deletion, the August 1 lists omitted the last detail.

Yet, in a state where power cuts can spark spontaneous protests, the deletion of 6.5 million names from voter rolls has been met with an uncanny stillness. Even in districts like Gopalganj, where one in six voters has been struck off the rolls, the streets remain calm. Many analysts attribute this to Bihar's voter apathy, characterised by chronically low voter turnout, barely 60 per cent in recent elections. Which, in turn, means 40 per cent of the voters have limited investment in their electoral rights. The ECI's month-long window for filing objections has also provided a safety valve, allowing voters to believe they can reclaim their names through proper procedures. While the silence at the draft roll offices may feel deceptively serene now, democracy itself is perhaps undergoing a decisive churn in Bihar. ■